Report on the Surface Web

A map of platforms and services on the indexed, publicly accessible web

1. Introduction

The Surface Web is the part of the internet that can be found by search engines and accessed by anyone with a browser, without special credentials, specific software or anonymity settings. It is the most visible face of the network and brings together the services most people use every day: social networks, news portals, government websites, video platforms, encyclopaedias and code repositories.

This report organises a selection of websites into ten broad categories: social networks, news, sport, betting, government, intelligence and investigation, operating systems, communities, knowledge and development, as well as video platforms and web portals. Its aim is to describe the role of each group, highlight the characteristics of each service and point out risks and good browsing practices.

2. Social Networks

Social networks are the spaces where users create profiles, produce content and interact with one another. They dominate the time people spend online and act as the main gateway to information for a large part of the population.

- **Facebook**: one of the pioneering networks on a global scale, it brings together personal profiles, groups, business pages and a marketplace for buying and selling between users.
- **Instagram**: focused on visual content, with photos, short videos, stories and direct messages. It is widely used by brands and content creators.
- **LinkedIn**: a professional network focused on careers, recruitment, networking and the publication of corporate content.
- **X**: a microblogging platform with short posts, strongly associated with public debate, real-time news and political discussion.
- **TikTok**: built around short videos and an algorithmic recommendation system that makes content go viral at great speed.
- **Pinterest**: works as a visual mood board for inspiration, with heavy use in interior design, fashion, cookery and creative projects.
- **Snapchat**: popularised ephemeral messages and augmented-reality filters, with a predominantly young audience.
- **Threads**: a text-based publishing network linked to the Instagram ecosystem, created as an alternative space for public conversation.
- **Mastodon**: a decentralised, open-source network made up of independent servers that communicate with one another, with moderation set by each community.
- **Bluesky**: a microblogging network that relies on an open protocol and gives users greater control over feeds and moderation.
- **Discord**: originally aimed at gamers, it now hosts communities on every subject, with servers, text and voice channels and live streaming.

Note: this group shows two visions of the internet. On one side are centralised, commercial platforms such as Facebook, Instagram and TikTok. On the other are decentralised, open projects

such as Mastodon and Bluesky.

3. News

Press outlets make up the journalistic layer of the Surface Web. They differ in funding model, editorial line, reach and language.

- **BBC**: a British public broadcaster with international coverage and services in dozens of languages, including Portuguese.
- **Folha de S.Paulo**: one of Brazil's leading newspapers, with national, political and economic coverage.
- **New York Times**: an influential American newspaper, known for investigative reporting and its digital subscription model.
- **Reuters**: a global news agency, a benchmark for financial information and a supplier of content to other outlets.
- **Associated Press**: a cooperative agency that distributes news, photographs and video to media outlets around the world.
- **CNN**: a television network with round-the-clock news coverage and a strong digital presence.
- **Deutsche Welle**: a German international broadcaster, with multilingual content and a focus on European and global coverage.
- **The Guardian**: a British newspaper with international coverage and largely open access to its content.
- **Al Jazeera**: a Qatar-based network, with strong coverage of the Middle East and of countries in the Global South.
- **G1**: a Brazilian news portal with national, regional and sports coverage.
- **Agência Brasil**: Brazil's public news agency, which offers content that other outlets are free to use.

Note: agencies such as Reuters and Associated Press act as news "wholesalers", supplying other portals. Comparing different sources is essential to reduce bias and identify disinformation.

4. Sport

Sport is one of the most widely consumed types of content on the web, and this category brings together everything from coverage portals to the bodies that organise competitions.

- **ESPN**: a portal and TV network with news, results, statistics and broadcasts.
- **Olympics**: the official website of the Olympic movement, with information on the Games, athletes, sports and history.
- **UFC**: a mixed martial arts organisation, with an events calendar, rankings and content on its fighters.
- **FIFA**: football's world governing body, responsible for World Cups and for regulating the sport.
- **Formula 1**: the championship's official site, with the calendar, results, teams and broadcasts.

- **NBA**: the United States' professional basketball league, with games, statistics and team content.
- **IBJJF**: the international federation for Brazilian jiu-jitsu, responsible for championships, rankings and rules.
- **IJF**: the international judo federation, which organises the world circuit and sets the sport's regulations.

Note: this group combines media outlets, commercial leagues and sports federations. The latter are the official source for rules, calendars and results.

5. Betting

- **Bet365**: one of the largest betting companies in the world, offering sports betting, casino games and in-play betting.
- **Betano**: a sports betting and casino platform with a strong presence in the Brazilian market.
- **Betfair**: known for its betting exchange, in which users bet against one another rather than against the house.

Risks and precautions: betting involves financial risk and the potential for addiction. Regulation varies from country to country, so it is important to use only operators licensed in the user's jurisdiction, set spending limits and avoid treating betting as a source of income. Fake sites that imitate betting companies are also a common route for scams.

6. Government

Government portals bring together public services, legislation, open data and official communications.

- **Gov.br**: the single portal for Brazilian federal government services, with document issuance, enquiries and digital identity.
- **USA.gov**: the official portal of the United States government, which organises access to federal agencies and services.
- **GOV.UK**: the unified portal of the United Kingdom government, often cited as a benchmark in digital public service design.
- **Portal da Transparência**: a Brazilian tool for public scrutiny, allowing users to follow public spending, transfers and benefits.
- **Germany Gov**: the German government's portal, with institutional information and public policy.
- **Finland Gov**: the Finnish government's portal, which reflects the high level of digitalisation of the country's public services.

Note: these sites are primary sources for legislation, official data and services. It is always best to confirm the official address, since fake public service sites are widely used in fraud.

7. Intelligence and Investigation

This category brings together security, intelligence and police cooperation bodies. Their websites are usually institutional in nature, publishing statements, alerts, wanted notices and guidance for the public.

- **FBI**: the United States' federal investigative agency, publishing cases, wanted persons and alerts.
- **CIA**: the American foreign intelligence agency, which publishes institutional material and declassified documents.
- **Europol**: the European police cooperation agency, focused on combating organised crime and terrorism.
- **Interpol**: an international organisation for cooperation between police forces in many countries, known for its international notices.
- **NSA**: an American agency linked to signals intelligence and information security.
- **CISA**: a United States agency focused on cybersecurity and the protection of critical infrastructure, issuing alerts on vulnerabilities.
- **Polícia Federal**: Brazil's federal judicial police, with channels for services, news and reporting crimes.

Note: the public content of these institutions is institutional and informative. Security alerts, such as those from CISA, are especially useful for professionals and organisations.

8. Operating Systems

Operating system websites are the official place for downloads, documentation and support. Both commercial products and community projects appear here.

- **Windows**: the proprietary system most widely used on personal computers.
- **Ubuntu**: a popular Linux distribution, beginner-friendly and widely used on servers and in the cloud.
- **Debian**: a traditional and stable distribution, the basis of many others, including Ubuntu.
- **Fedora**: a community-supported distribution sponsored by Red Hat, which tends to bring in recent technologies.
- **Arch Linux**: a minimalist, rolling-release distribution aimed at users who want complete control over configuration.
- **Linux Mint**: a distribution focused on simplicity and ease of use, well suited to those moving from Windows.
- **Kali Linux**: a distribution aimed at offensive security and penetration testing, with many tools pre-installed.
- **FreeBSD**: a Unix-like system that is not based on Linux, known for networking, performance and a permissive licence.
- **OpenBSD**: a system focused on security and correct code, the origin of projects such as OpenSSH.
- **TempleOS**: an experimental and idiosyncratic system, created by a single programmer, which became a curiosity of computing culture.

Note: always download systems from the official website and check the checksums or signatures of the images, as tampered images are a real risk.

9. Communities

- **Reddit**: an aggregator of themed communities, known as subreddits, where users vote on and discuss content. It serves as a source of opinions, tutorials and debates on almost any subject.
- **Stack Overflow**: a question-and-answer platform for programming, a reference point for developers solving technical problems.

Note: the value of these communities lies in collective intelligence, but the content is user-generated and should be checked with care.

10. Knowledge

- **Wikipedia**: a free, collaborative encyclopaedia maintained by volunteers and one of the most consulted sources on the internet.
- **Internet Archive**: a non-profit digital library that preserves websites, books, audio and video, including its web page archiving service.
- **NASA**: the American space agency, with images, scientific data, mission news and educational material.

Note: this category plays a role in preserving and democratising knowledge. Wikipedia should be used as a starting point, checking the references it cites.

11. Development and Technology

- **GitHub**: a code-hosting platform with version control, used for both open and private projects.
- **Cloudflare**: an infrastructure company offering a content delivery network, protection against attacks and DNS services.
- **OWASP**: a community dedicated to web application security, known for guides and lists of the main risks.
- **Mozilla**: the organisation behind the Firefox browser, which champions an open web and privacy.
- **GNU**: a free software project that supplied a large part of the essential tools of Linux-based systems and defends users' freedom.

Note: these sites underpin the technical workings of the web, from code to security and infrastructure.

12. Video Platforms and Web Portals

- **YouTube**: the world's largest video platform, with content ranging from entertainment to education, music and live streams. For many people it is also the second most used search engine.

- **Yahoo**: a historic internet portal, bringing together news, email, finance and search. It represents the portal model that dominated the web before the era of social networks.

13. Overall Analysis

Common characteristics of the Surface Web

- **Accessibility**: open access, with no special tools required, and indexing by search engines.
- **Concentration**: a few large companies dominate a considerable share of traffic, especially in social networks and video.
- **Monetisation**: advertising, subscriptions and user data sustain many of these services.
- **Diversity of models**: private companies, public bodies, non-profit organisations and community projects all coexist.

Main risks

1. **Disinformation**: especially on social networks and open communities.
2. **Phishing and fake sites**: imitations of banks, governments, betting companies and social networks.
3. **Privacy**: large-scale data collection by commercial platforms.
4. **Addiction and overuse**: linked to social networks, short videos and betting.
5. **Data breaches**: any service that requires registration can be a target.

Good practice

- Check the address (URL) and security certificate before entering any data.
- Use strong, unique passwords, with two-factor authentication.
- Cross-check news against more than one reliable source.
- Download software and operating systems only from official websites.
- Review the privacy settings of social networks regularly.

14. Conclusion

The Surface Web is the best-known part of the internet, but also the most diverse. Within it sit platforms that shape public debate, institutions that provide essential services, free knowledge projects and the technical infrastructure that keeps everything running. Understanding how these categories fit together helps people to browse more safely, assess sources better and recognise the role of each type of service in the digital ecosystem.

The Surface Web is only one part of the internet, as there are layers that search engines do not index. Even so, it is where most everyday use is concentrated and therefore deserves particular attention in terms of security, privacy and the quality of information.